VIENNA, AUSTRIA

Albertina: Masterpieces

Twenty works draw attention to bare paper, unfinished passages and the expressive work of a line.



A drawing can describe a face closely and leave the clothes unresolved. A view of a town can move from coloured buildings into outlines on pale paper. These differences of finish are among the pleasures of the selection: they make decisions visible that a uniformly polished surface might conceal.

The works range from formal likenesses to loosely coloured landscapes, with Bruegel's densely narrated proverb offering a different kind of economy. Here, every smaller fish extends an argument already made by the largest. Across these approaches, ask where enough information has been supplied and what a picture gains by stopping there. The answer changes with the subject, the material and the scale of attention.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/albertina

The selection · 20

1. Maria Theresa
   Jean-Étienne Liotard · 1762
2. Saint John in the Forest
   Matthias Grünewald · 1515
3. Children on Their Way to Work in the Fields
   Peter Fendi · 1840
4. Coastal Landscape at Hvitsten
   Edvard Munch · 1915
5. The Fool
   Paul Klee · 1927
6. Hans Luther
   Lucas Cranach the Elder · c. 1527
7. Picnic on the Beach
   August Macke · 1913
8. Man in a Grey-Striped Coat and Red Waistcoat
   Marie-Adélaïde Duvieux · 1794–1798
9. Still Life with Bottle, Bread and Red Wallpaper
   Alexej von Jawlensky · 1915
10. The Evening Prayer
    Peter Fendi · 1839
11. View of Ischl
    Rudolf von Alt · 1830
12. Young Girl with a Flowered Hat
    Alexej von Jawlensky · 1910
13. Big Fish Eat Small Fish
    Pieter Bruegel the Elder · 1556
14. Floral Still Life
    Paul Signac · 1920-1924
15. Le Havre with Rain Clouds
    Paul Signac · 1922
16. The Martyrdom of Saint Ursula
    Martin Schongauer · 1475-1490
17. Garden at Wannsee
    Max Liebermann · 1921
18. Rodez
    Paul Signac · 1923
19. Ruins of Diocletian’s Palace at Split
    Rudolf von Alt · 1841
20. Tiger
    Anton Romako · 1870

01 / 20

Maria Theresa

Jean-Étienne Liotard

1762 · Pastel · Albertina



Jean-Étienne Liotard. Portrait of Maria Theresa, Sovereign of Austria, Hungary and Bohemia. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/jean-etienne-liotard/portrait-of-maria-theresa-sovereign-of-austria-hungary-and-bohemia-1762 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The settled hands and richly worked pale dress give the ruler a formal presentation without a crowded surrounding spectacle. Liotard concentrates on distinctions among skin, lace and heavier fabric. Soft light separates those materials within the restrained setting. The portrait's public dignity is carried as much by its measured description of surfaces as by the sitter's composed pose.

Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

Saint John in the Forest

Matthias Grünewald

1515 · Chalk · Albertina



Matthias Grünewald. St. John in the Forest. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/matthias-grunewald/st-john-in-the-forest-1515 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The light-robed figure emerges through a restless field of trunks and marks. Curving fabric and twisting wood establish related movements around him, making the forest more than a dark backing. Grünewald lets the setting remain active against the solitary saint. Contrast makes the body locatable while the surrounding lines resist settling into a quiet enclosure.

Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

Children on Their Way to Work in the Fields

Peter Fendi

1840 · Albertina



Peter Fendi. Children on Their Way to Work in the Fields. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Containers and smaller companions give the children practical burdens to carry. Fendi distinguishes ages and tasks within a compact group, leaving bare feet and simple clothes clearly readable. The scene's charm should not erase the work identified by its title. The bodies are engaged in obligations that complicate an easy account of carefree childhood.

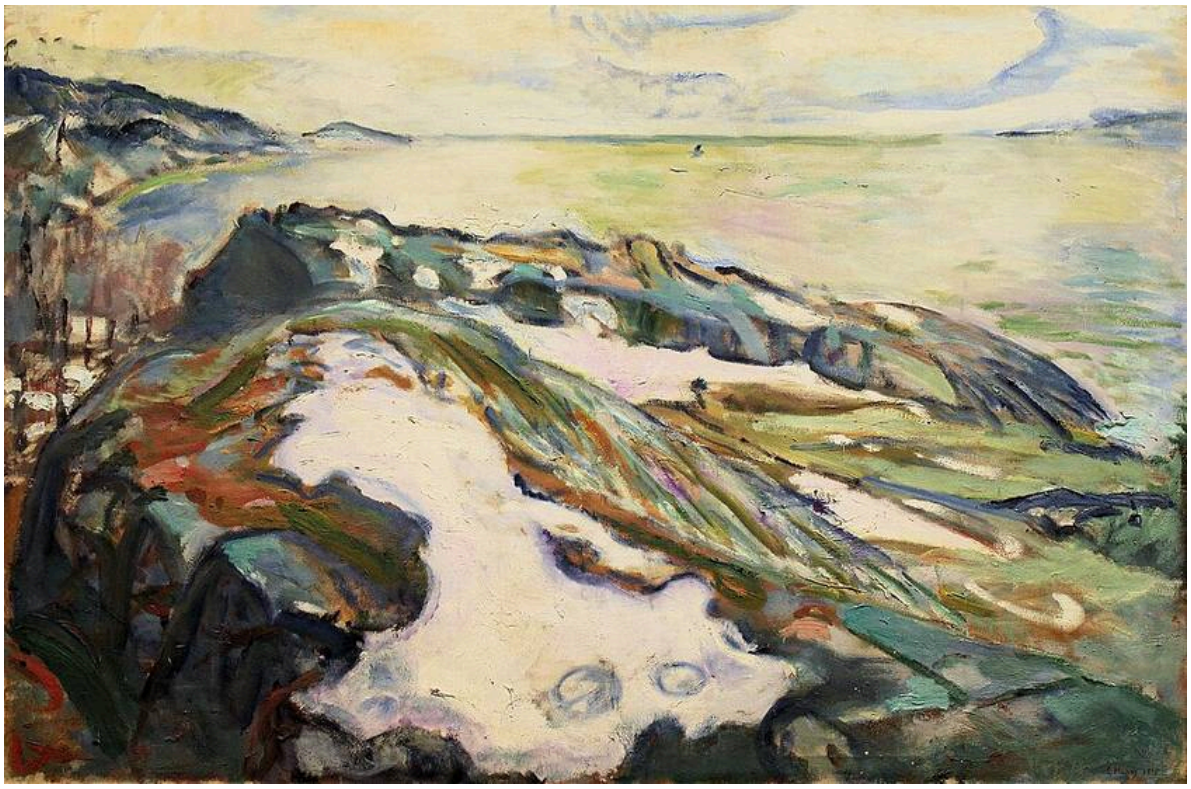
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 30632

04 / 20

Coastal Landscape at Hvitsten

Edvard Munch

1915 · Albertina



Edvard Munch. Coastal Landscape at Hvitsten. Image credit: Dguendel; Own work. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Wien-Innenstadt,_Albertina,_Edvard_Munch,_Winterlandschaft.JPG. CC BY 4.0 (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · CC BY 4.0

Curves recur through low rocks and irregular shorelines, guiding the coloured strokes toward water and sky. Munch gives the coast a continuous rhythm without making its surfaces identical. The movement of the brush connects solid terrain to the surrounding air. Following one bend into another can explain the arrangement more clearly than listing the landscape's separate objects.

Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

The Fool

Paul Klee

1927 · Albertina



Paul Klee. Der Narr. Image credit: Paul Klee; Own work; Photographic credit: Wikisympathisant. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Klee_1927_Der_Narr_2021-08.jpg. CC BY-SA 4.0 (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · CC BY-SA 4.0

Angular coloured parts gather into a small figure against darkness. Thin limbs and nearby circles leave its balance looking provisional, as though another arrangement remains possible. Klee supplies enough bodily cues for a character to emerge without fully modelling it. Recognition happens among the shapes, rather than being completed before colour is added.

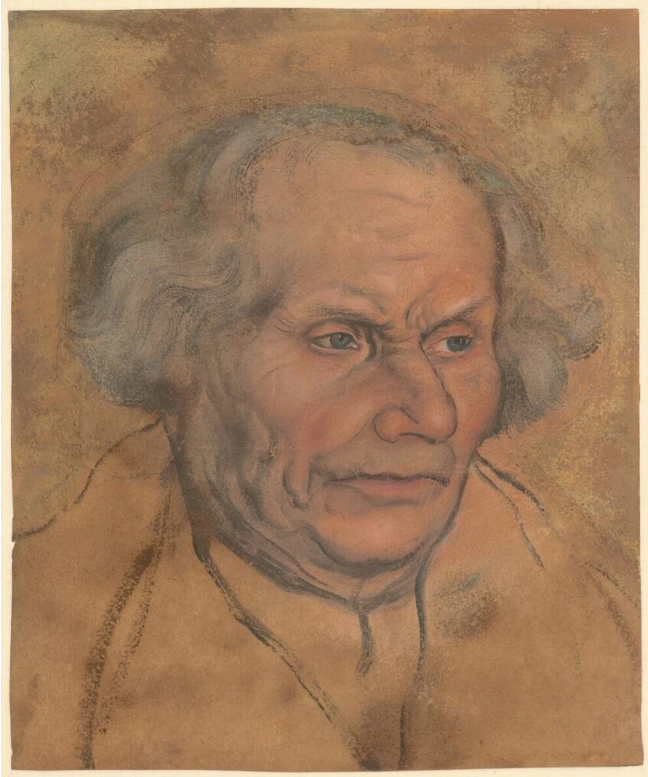
Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

Hans Luther

Lucas Cranach the Elder

c. 1527 · Albertina



Lucas Cranach the Elder. Hans Luther. Image credit: Lucas Cranach the Elder; https://sammlungenonline.albertina.at/?query=search=/record/objectnumbersearch= [26156]&showtype=record. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Lucas_Cranach_d._%C3%84._-_Albertina_26156,_Hans_Luther_(1459-1530).jpg. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

Fine lines and restrained colour concentrate on the eyes, mouth and thinning hair, while clothing receives less development. Cranach makes the distribution of study apparent on the sheet. The warm paper remains part of the head's setting rather than disappearing behind a fully worked ground. Likeness gathers where observation has been most closely sustained.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 26156

07 / 20

Picnic on the Beach

August Macke

1913 · Albertina



August Macke. Picnic on the Beach. WikiArt: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt per-object label)

Transparent red, blue, green and yellow pass between figures and setting, with gaps of bare paper interrupting the scene. Macke lets colour do much of the separating that an outline might otherwise provide. The gathering stays readable, but its components also act as shapes with their own relationships. Empty intervals help preserve that double function.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: DL83

08 / 20

Man in a Grey-Striped Coat and Red Waistcoat

Marie-Adélaïde Duvieux

1794–1798 · Albertina



Marie-Adélaïde Duvieux. Portrait of a man in a grey-striped frock coat and a red waistcoat. Image credit: Marie-Adélaïde Duvieux. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The oval keeps the smiling face close, leaving little room for a descriptive environment. Fine coat stripes lead into larger contrasts of red waistcoat and white neckcloth. Duvieux makes dress the portrait's principal setting. The small format rewards attention to how those repeated lines support, rather than compete with, the sitter's expression.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 29257

09 / 20

Still Life with Bottle, Bread and Red Wallpaper

Alexej von Jawlensky

1915 · Albertina



Alexej von Jawlensky. Still Life with Bottle, Bread and red Wallpaper with Swallows. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Birds and round forms on the red wallpaper compete with the objects in front. Jawlensky reduces the wall's usual role as a recessive background, bringing its decoration forward into the still life's activity. Bottle, bread and pattern occupy related pictorial ground. Space remains present, but strong colour makes the distinction between object and setting less secure.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: GE140DL

10 / 20

The Evening Prayer

Peter Fendi

1839 · Albertina



Peter Fendi. The Evening Prayer. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The children perform a shared ritual under an adult's nearby supervision. Pictures, furniture and an open door place that learning within an organised domestic room. Fendi makes repeated practice visible through the gathering rather than through a spectacular religious event. The surrounding order becomes part of the account of how conduct is observed and passed on.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 28334

11 / 20

View of Ischl

Rudolf von Alt

1830 · Albertina



Rudolf von Alt. View of Ischl. WikiArt: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt per-object label)

Coloured buildings coexist with structures still held in outline and broad pale areas of paper. Rudolf von Alt leaves several degrees of description available on one sheet. The rocky hill and town remain locatable, while the eye can follow the passage from measured drawing into fuller colour. The unfinished areas help reveal how the view has been assembled.

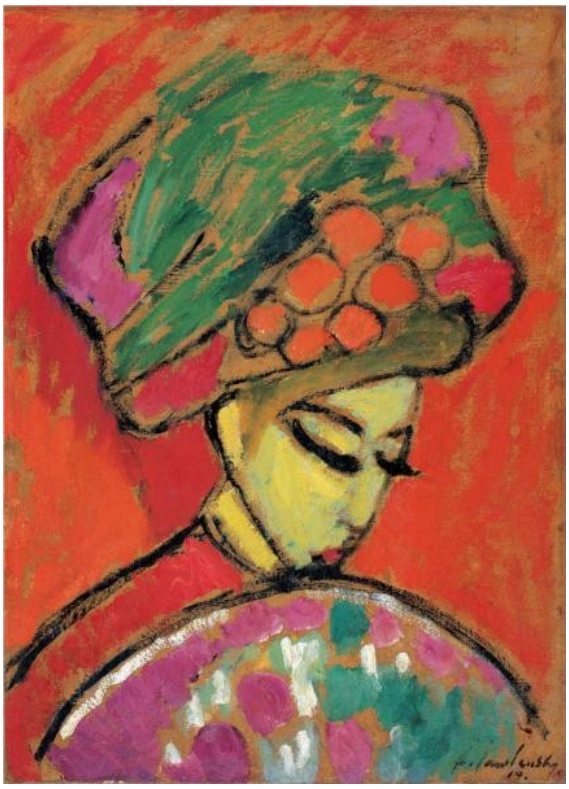
Object source · Open artwork

12 / 20

Young Girl with a Flowered Hat

Alexej von Jawlensky

1910 · Albertina



Alexej von Jawlensky. Young Girl with a flowered hat. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The bowed face remains quiet beneath a large green hat and bright flowers. Red presses around the firmly outlined head and shoulders, giving the setting more overt force than the pose. Jawlensky does not need natural illumination to explain those contrasts. Colour can be assertive while the person it surrounds remains withdrawn in direction and gesture.

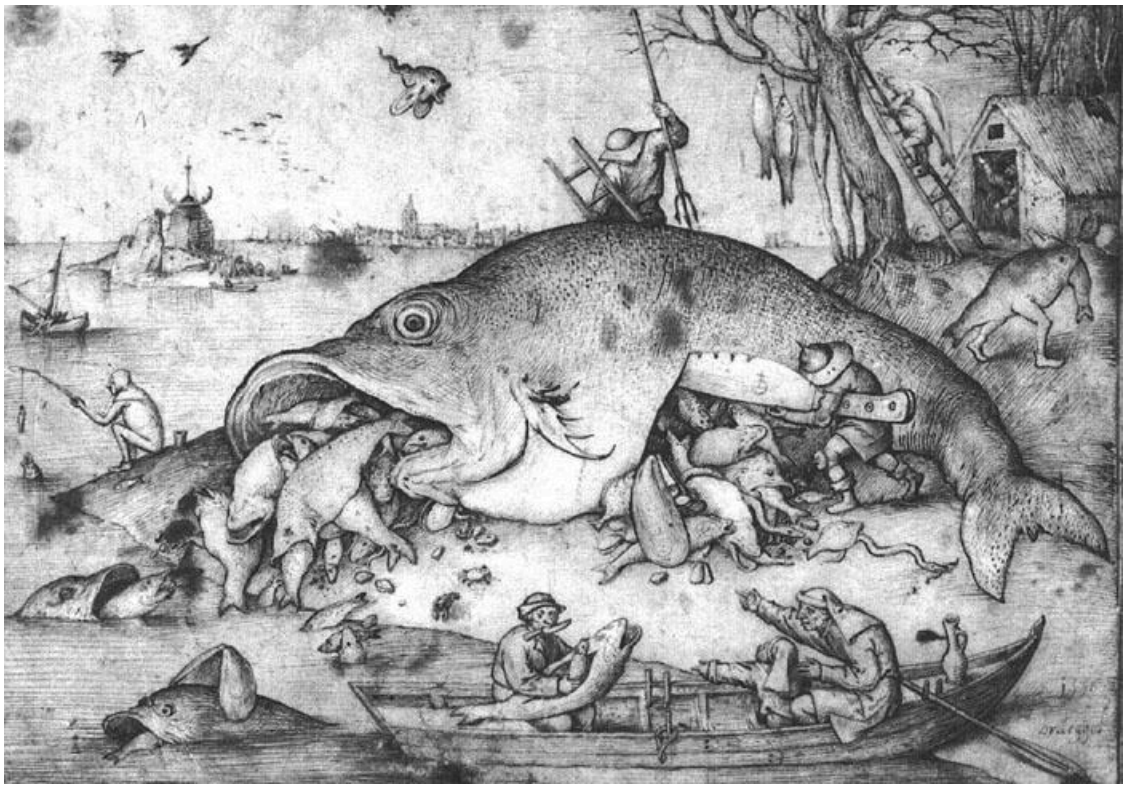
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: GE52DL

13 / 20

Big Fish Eat Small Fish

Pieter Bruegel the Elder

1556 · Albertina



Pieter Bruegel the Elder. Big fishes eat small fishes. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The giant fish has swallowed smaller fish, which have swallowed smaller ones in turn. Bruegel makes a proverb recur at several scales, extending unequal power across the whole scene. This is the 1556 drawing. The later published engraving is a separate object, and its attribution to Bosch adds a history of selling images to the history of the design.

Object source · Open artwork

14 / 20

Floral Still Life

Paul Signac

1920-1924 · Albertina



Paul Signac. Floral still life. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The bouquet appears full even though much of the paper remains untouched. Loose colour and light lines supply the flowers' spread, while the patterned jug and nearby books give the arrangement a more compact base. Signac lets gaps remain active within the description. The sheet avoids equating abundance in the subject with complete coverage of the surface.

Object source · Open artwork

15 / 20

Le Havre with Rain Clouds

Paul Signac

1922 · Albertina



Paul Signac. Le Havre with rain clouds. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Slanting marks make the sky as active as the harbour beneath it. Small colour patches locate boats and façades without fixing every edge. Signac's broken handling suits a view whose conditions are changing. The buildings provide orientation, but rain clouds determine how much certainty and stability their outlines can retain.

Object source · Open artwork

16 / 20

The Martyrdom of Saint Ursula

Martin Schongauer

1475-1490 · Albertina



Martin Schongauer. Marter of St. Ursula. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The boat's strong boundary holds the crowded figures together within an intricate network of lines. Beyond it, buildings and terrain recede into a larger setting. Schongauer makes the narrative group distinguishable before its many details are read. That enclosing form gives the eye a place to return when the surrounding drawing becomes dense.

Object source · Open artwork

17 / 20

Garden at Wannsee

Max Liebermann

1921 · Kohle · Albertina



ALBERTINA, Wien. Public Domain — ALBERTINA free download up to 1200 pixels. Full source frame preserved; proportional resize and JPEG compression. · Public Domain — ALBERTINA free download up to 1200 pixels

Paths and beds give the garden an underlying plan, while uneven strokes let the foliage resist perfectly neat boundaries. Liebermann keeps cultivation and growth in the same image. The ordered spaces remain navigable despite the activity of the marks. Following a path, then losing its edge in vegetation, makes that relationship particularly easy to see.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 23129

18 / 20

Rodez

Paul Signac

1923 · Albertina



Paul Signac. Rodez. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The tall church tower provides a firm vertical among loose blue, yellow and pink washes. Signac can leave much of the sky open because that measure holds the city in place. Façades and trees gather as colour accents around it. A recognisable landmark gives the lighter passages freedom to remain suggestive rather than fully enclosed.

Object source · Open artwork

19 / 20

Ruins of Diocletian’s Palace at Split

Rudolf von Alt

1841 · Albertina



Rudolf von Alt. Ruins of Diocletian at Split. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

One arch reveals another passage, turning depth into a sequence of openings. Warm stone alternates with shadow as the view proceeds inward. The small figures supply scale and evidence of continued occupation, keeping the ancient structure within a used environment. Rudolf von Alt lets the building's age coexist with its capacity to shelter present activity.

Object source · Open artwork

20 / 20

Tiger

Anton Romako

1870 · Watercolour · Albertina



Anton Romako. Tiger. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/anton-romako/tiger-1870 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The resting body is described more firmly than the pale ground and nearby plants. Its weight can therefore remain substantial without a fully elaborated habitat. The outward turn of the head adds alertness to the long repose. Romako uses unequal finish to concentrate the encounter on an animal that is still but not inattentive.

Object source · Open artwork

Give the untouched surface a role

Compare an extensively worked passage with the paper or ground beside it. The transition may reveal more about the picture's decisions than another descriptive detail would. Many works in this selection are light-sensitive; check the Albertina's actual exhibition programme and object information rather than assuming that collection highlights remain permanently on view.

Further reading

The Elements of Drawing

John Ruskin · Read free · English

Ruskin’s exercises in observing edges, tones and natural forms fit the close looking these sheets invite. His practical instructions give readers something to try after studying the images.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

Artline · Albertina: Masterpieces